

Fielding and fitness: progress?

India's bowlers were effective but faltered at key moments. Against New Zealand, 13 extras were conceded. Against Australia, India's fielding was abysmal, with five dropped catches in a must-win game.

That said, Richa took her disappointment of dropping Suzie Bates early in the New Zealand game to training, practising the right technique but the nerves behind the stumps were still evident throughout. Asha and others missed crucial chances, while Arundhati would have finished with a far higher tally of wickets if her fielders had held up their end of the bargain.

Coach Muzumdar's mantra of prioritising fitness and fielding fell flat on both counts. India was sluggish when it came to running between the wickets, but it improved in the matches against Sri Lanka and Australia, driven by the strong desire to survive.

Harmanpreet: the batter or captain?

A question for the future is whether India values Harmanpreet more as a captain or a power-hitter. While she has the backing of the selectors and coach — evidenced by her retention as captain for the New Zealand ODI series — her ability to turn games around with the bat cannot be overlooked. Former India captain Mithali Raj has advocated for Jemimah Rodrigues to be groomed as the next to lead, preferring her over Smriti, who currently serves as vice-captain.

Smriti stepped in to lead the team when Harmanpreet sat out the second innings of the Sri Lanka game due to a neck strain, caused by a blow to the head during practice before the World Cup. Smriti's WPL triumph with Royal Challengers Bengaluru has helped smooth out some of the rough edges in her leadership, boosting her confidence in both planning and execution.

Jemimah, on the other hand, has been energising the team with her pep talks and leading huddles. Her



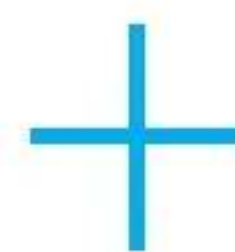
All-weather player: Jemimah Rodrigues, a versatile player willing to adapt to any role, ended up floating in the top order, focusing on maximising runs rather than stabilising a shaky batting line-ups. GETTY IMAGES

presence galvanises the field, a gap that is keenly felt when she isn't around. Additionally, she steps up to address the media candidly, particularly after disappointing losses.

"Lil J isn't Lil J anymore. This is my fourth World Cup," Jemimah remarked in an ICC interview. With the future in mind, the Indian think tank might consider giving this globe-trotting batter a spot in the leadership group, shaping her role in alignment with the team's evolving pace.

Following its early exit from the tournament, the Indian team has had time to regroup and reflect on the result. Some players, like Deepti Sharma and Yastika Bhatia, quickly returned to domestic T20 cricket. There's little time to dwell on the past. World champion New Zealand, whose captain Sophie Devine highlighted the win against India as the turning point in their campaign, will visit Ahmedabad for three ODIs in the coming days.

With a 50-over World Cup less than a year away, this Indian side has much to prove. The true test will be whether it can channel its heartbreak into hunger for success on the grandest stage, especially in front of a home crowd.



INDIA IN T20 WORLD CUPS

2009 in England: Semifinal

2010 in West Indies: Semifinal

2012 in Sri Lanka: Group Stage

2014 in Bangladesh: Group Stage

2016 in India: Group Stage

2018 in West Indies: Semifinal

2020 in Australia: Runner-up

2023 in South Africa: Semifinal

2024 in the UAE: Group Stage



BEST BATTER AND BOWLER FOR INDIA

Best bowlers: Arundhati Reddy and Renuka Singh - 4 games, 7 wickets each

Best batter: Harmanpreet Kaur, 150 runs in 4 games; Two fifties, Strike Rate: 133.92